

Colorado Field Ornithologists Sight Record Form

CFO-RC FILE X:

Rcd 2/18/01 (2 photos) wgl

RESULTS:

Species:(Common Name) Hudsonian Godwit

(Scientific Name) *Limosa haemastica*

Date(s) of occurrence: 16 April 2000

Number of birds seen: 1

Sex: Female

Plumage: Molting into alternate

Location Thurston Reservoir, Prowers County, CO

Length of observation: 15 minutes

Time(s) of observation:

Other observers who saw the bird(s) with you: Mark Janos, Tony Leukering and Brandon Percival

Other Observers who independently saw the bird(s): None

Conditions: Warm. Sun high in sky. Some heat waves.

Optical equipment used: B & L Elite 20 - 60x scope and Tony's Leica 32 wide scope

Distance from bird(s) (estimated unless otherwise noted): 250 meters. Far.

Habitat: Shore of man made reservoir

Details: The four of us were scanning a distant spit when I found this bird. The shape was like that of a large yellowlegs, or small godwit. The bird was so far away that I was not sure at first if it was a Greater Yellowlegs or, possibly, my long overdue first Hudsonian Godwit for Colorado, or something else. It was difficult to make out many details. The bird stood up and started walking around. At that point the very long slightly upturned bill (roughly 2.5x the length of the head) was obvious. Size was difficult to judge, given the distance and optical properties that make closer birds seem smaller relative to farther objects. The bird seemed to be a little bit smaller than the avocets (Figure 1), but made the Green-winged Teal look rather small (figure 2). The bird lifted its wings and I saw a black tail, white rump and conspicuous, though narrow, wingstripe. I was not positive, however, if this was on the underwing or the upperwing. Given the upturned bill, I was fairly confident the bird was NOT a Black-tailed Godwit. I told the rest of the group that I had a Hudsonian Godwit. We continued looking at the bird. Eventually, the bird raised the wings again and we had a good look at the underwing that was black (NOT white as in Black-tailed Godwit) with a relatively narrow but conspicuous white wingstripe, similar to that on the upperwing.

The captured images in figures 1 and 2 are not very good. Still, figure 1 shows a bird with only moderate barring on the flanks (less than in an alternate Marbled Godwit), and the overall shape of the head and bill look more similar to a Hudsonian Godwit. This along with the wing pattern rule out Marbled Godwit (and Bar-tailed). The bill is not as straight as in Black-tailed Godwit (figure 1 and 2) and the underwing was not white. The pinkish color to the base of the bill in figure 1 rules out Willet and Greater Yellowlegs (as does the wing pattern).

What is your prior experience with this and similarly appearing species? I have seen hundreds of Hudsonian Godwits, mostly in spring in Alaska and Wisconsin. I have seen thousands of Marbled Godwits in many plumages, and a couple hundred Bar-tailed Godwits.

List books, guides, recordings or other sources consulted and how this influenced your identification (during and after observation): We looked in Collins (Europe) to remind ourselves of how to rule out Black-tailed and Bar-tailed Godwits.

This report is from notes made the night following the observation.

Date of written report: 3 February 2001

Reporting observer: Christopher L. Wood, zeledonia@att.net

Signature: *Christopher L. Wood (electronic submission)*

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Photos: Video taken by me. Best stills included here.



Figure 1



Figure 2